returning to supervise the building of her husband's magnificent tomb. His mother, Hamida Banu, was as peripatetic as Akbar himself; the *Akbarnama* is littered with instances of her travels across her son's empire.

Many of these women enjoyed a great deal of power, too. When Akbar went chasing after Mirza Hakim for the last time, for example, he had two governors keeping watch over Bengal and Gujarat. 'The King's mother,' writes Father Monserrate, 'was to be superior to both of these, and was to have charge of the province of . . . Delinum.'

It was from knowing the kind of influence the harem exercised on Akbar that poor Makhdum-ul-Mulk and Abdun Nabi had tried to smuggle themselves back to Hindustan under Gulbadan's skirts. Indeed, Babur and his descendants shared a deep-seated love and respect for their older female relatives. The historian and recent biographer of Babur, Stephen Dale, writes of how Babur would kneel to acknowledge older women in his family.[47] Similarly, Abul Fazl writes of Akbar and his mother, Hamida Banu: 'everything that lady says is granted by the emperor'.[48]

And yet, a change was creeping upon Akbar's harem, as it had crept upon every power centre in his realm, from the Uzbek warlords to the disgruntled ulema. Akbar might not refuse his mother anything, for example, but he had not hesitated in imprisoning her brother.

Muazzam, the young man who had played detective in Persia and recovered Humayun's rubies, had done little to distinguish himself thereafter. Eccentric, unreliable and increasingly violent, Hamida's brother had been exiled in exasperation by Humayun and Bairam Khan both, but Akbar gave him another chance. Sometime in 1564, however, Muazzam murdered his wife. The girl's mother had suspected he might do some such thing, and had pleaded with Akbar to rescue her daughter, but the emperor arrived too late. All he could do was have Muazzam imprisoned in the dungeons of Gwalior, where he died.

'Relatives are like scorpions in the harm they do,' writes Badauni in his account of the affair, and Akbar might have agreed. Muazzam had been by Hamida's side all through that terrible journey she made as a fifteen-year-old, thirsty and pregnant in a desert full of enemies; he had been with her on her Persian exile. It isn't impossible to imagine that she asked for mercy on his behalf. If she did, Akbar was not swayed.